The Copts in Egypt, and the various Christian sects in Lebanon, are growing as well. But it is undeniably one of the safest, most tolerant places for Christians in the region, free from the communal violence and sectarian rhetoric that is prevalent in Egypt, to say nothing of the carnage in Iraq and Syria.

Despite this, Christians (like Muslims) have not exactly been eager to enlist in the Israeli army. Recruitment numbers were historically quite low, just a few dozen young men annually, from a pool (in recent years) of perhaps 1,400 potential recruits. The plight of the Palestinians—the desire not to serve in an occupying force—is of course a major reason. Abd el-Aziz el-Zoubi, an Arab Knesset member in the 1960s and 1970s, described his people as one "whose country is at war with its nation."

"If you accept yourself as a Palestinian, you don't go into an army which maintains occupation or kills Palestinians," Michel Sabbah, the former Latin Patriarch of Jerusalem, said before the pope's visit.

Yet there are signs of a change. If enlistment numbers are any guide, a growing number of Christians disagree with Sabbah. Since 2012, the number of annual Christian recruits has climbed above 100—small in absolute terms, but a notable increase in relative terms. Officials expect it will keep rising. It is hard to ignore the link with the worsening violence across the Levant. Several teenagers in Jish who were mulling whether or not to enlist mentioned the battle of Ma'loula, an ancient Aramaic-speaking village in Syria that was occupied by the jihadi group Jabhat al-Nusra in late 2013. The group, which is the Syrian branch of Al-Qaeda (now known as Jabhat Fatah al-Sham), kidnapped a dozen Greek Orthodox nuns and held them hostage for months.

There are also less idealistic reasons for enlisting. Veterans are accorded a range of benefits in Israeli society. In the weeks before the pope's visit, Yair Lapid, then the finance minister, was pushing a bill to exempt first-time homebuyers from tax. He wanted to limit the benefit to Israelis who had served in the army, or the officially sanctioned "national service" program, which offers a civilian alternative to military service. Some employers use army service as a criterion for hiring, which effectively discriminates against Christian and Muslim applicants. And the army can provide useful skills: many of Israel's high-tech entrepreneurs, for example, are veterans of Unit 8200, an elite branch of the intelligence services. (It